

Rare Caravaggio art exhibition attracts global audience in Rome

By Kaya Equevilley

A one of a kind art exhibition showcases 24 works by Caravaggio in Rome at the Palazzo Barberini attracting an audience from around the world.

On exhibition are 24 paintings by Michelangelo Merisi, also known as Caravaggio, at Palazzo Barberini in Rome, March 7 to July 6. This exhibition, Caravaggio 2025, coincides with the Jubilee events. This exhibition holds paintings by Caravaggio that now live around the world. From the works on display, nine are from foreign lenders (five from the United States alone), according to The New York Times.

The collection of art is curated by Francesca Cappelletti, Maria Cristina Terzaghi, and Thomas Clement Salomon. It is known as one of the “most important and ambitious projects dedicated to Michelangelo Merisi, known as Caravaggio (1571-1610)” according to The Galleria Borghese.

Thomas Clement Salomon, the director of the National Galleries of Ancient Art, said to The New York Times that the gallery did not ask any churches to loan their paintings because of the Jubilee.

“Seeing all of these pieces together in one space is really astonishing,” said Kim Allen from New York City. For many of these pieces, they have never been on display in the same room before.

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Holding this exhibition in Rome is also connected to the roots and history of Caravaggio. Spending much of his artistic career in Rome, it became the home for many of his works. After killing a man in a brawl, Caravaggio fled to Malta, though it took a couple of months to make the journey. This current exhibition is organized chronologically, showcasing the artist's career starting with his arrival in Rome. This timeline includes when Caravaggio could only afford to paint himself, to use his art as a means to gain a pardon from Pope Paul V.

Art historians agree that there are about 60 paintings that are attributed to Caravaggio, meaning just over one third of them are on display in this showcase. In addition, there are many works by the artists in churches around Rome.

A portrait titled Maffeo Barberini is on public display for the first time, and belongs to a private collection. Also on display are other famous works by Caravaggio, *Ecce Homo*, *Martha and Mary*, *Saint Catherine*, and *Judith Beheading Holofernes*.

The Jubilee refers to the Roman Catholic Holy Year, which takes place every 25 years. Rome is expecting over 30 million visitors in 2025 because of the Jubilee.

When artwork goes on loan, there are details such as insurance, photorights, contracts, transportation, protection, and artwork documentation that go into the process. These decisions are made in agreement between the owner of the artwork and the individual requesting the loan. Every loan in an exhibition can have a different agreement.

At the Palazzo Barberini in Rome, the Caravaggio 2025 exhibit is open for timed ticketed entry on March 26. This exhibition is organized by the Galleria Borghese and supported by the General Directorate of Museums, the Ministry of Culture, and the Main Partner Intesa Sanpaolo.



Before the exhibition door open at 9 a.m. a line forms on March 26 at the Palazzo Barberini. Ticket holders range from Italian, American, German, British, and more. Before the doors opened on March 26, a museum employee placed a “sold out” sign at the end of the line.



Museum employees scan online tickets to the exhibit on March 26. To enter the Caravaggio 2025 special showcase, viewers must purchase a ticket prior to arrival at Palazzo Barberini. Ticket prices start at 18 euros but reduced price tickets are available if audience members meet criteria such as age, pass holders, Intesa employees, and ALI members, specified by Coop Culture. CoopCulture is the platform to purchase tickets for the exhibition. This exhibition is closed on Mondays.



In the opening room of the Caravaggio exhibition eight paintings highlight his start as an artist in Rome on March 26.

“Seeing details [Caravaggio] includes in person is almost magical,” says Cynthia Luther.

Luther is a art teacher from Germany in Rome for the Caravaggio 2025 exhibition. While the exhibit was the main reason for her trip, Luther used the time to visit other museums and churches as well.



The Portrait of Maffeo Barberini by Caravaggio is on display for the public for the first time since its discovery in the second room of the exhibit. Placed next to another portrait of Maffeo Barberini by Caravaggio creates a notable and new dynamic said exhibit attendees on March 26.



A woman takes a photo of the label next to Judith Beheading Holofernes, a painting created in 1598-1599 by Caravaggio on March 26. This is one of five works in the second room of the Caravaggio 2025 exhibition.



Residents from Germany, Italy, America, and France view Judith Beheading Holofernes by Caravaggio on March 26. There are five other works that hang in the third room of this exhibition. This piece belongs to the Gallerie Nazionali and hangs in Palazzo Barberini.



In the third room of Caravaggio 2025 exhibition titled The Sacred and The Tragic Between Rome and Naples eight works of art hang. Two pieces have a no photo signs. Guards stationed next to the paintings enforced the policy on March 26. In the loan agreement the owners of those works requested no photos, according to Logan Flux, a guard at Palazzo Barberini.

“Seeing all of these pieces together in one space is really astonishing,” says Kim Allen from New York City. Allen is a spanish teacher and came to Rome for this exhibition. Many of these pieces, have never been on display in the same room before.



One visitor holds their cell phone as the free audio guide provided by the museum plays providing details about Caravaggio's San Giovanni Battista painting in the third room of the exhibit on March 26.

The free audio guide is uploaded to the phone through an app and provides additional detail into each piece of art in the exhibit.



Exhibit attendees listen to audio guides while they observe Saint Francis in Prayer and Supper by Emmaus by Caravaggio in the third room of the showcase on March 26. The two works that hang in the background are Flagellation of Christ and David with the head of Goliath.



Ward Landrigan, a 10-year-old boy from New York City points out a detail he notices in *The Martyrdom of Saint Ursula* by Caravaggio to his father on March 26.

“I like the emotion in how he paints, it’s revolutionary,” says Ward.

“We were lucky to get tickets,” says Neyko Landrigan, Ward’s father.

Ward is learning about ancient roman history in school. While on a one week spring break with his family in Rome they read a New York Times article about the Caravaggio 2025 exhibition. Since the family was in town, they added the exhibition to their itinerary.

